ʿIrfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

Based on a lecture series by
Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour

Edited by
Zafar Abbas Juma

An invitation

وَأَنِرْ أَبْصَارَ قُلُوبِنَا بِضِيَاءِ نَظَرِهَا إِلَيْكَ حَتَّىٰ تَخْرِقَ أَبْصَارُ الْقُلُوبِ حُجُبَ النُّورِ فَتَصِلَ إِلَىٰ مَعْدِنِ الْعَظَمَةِ

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.[1]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

What is ʿirfan?

These words come from the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, a prayer many of us recite in the month of Shaʿban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through even the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. It is a request to see God with the heart and to be near Him. Requests like this one were written for us, by the Imams (as), as an endeavour for the ordinary believer.

Despite saying these words in our munajats and on auspicious occasions, we find that seeking to know God does not feature in our day-to-day routine. Praying, fasting, and paying what is due, the *wajibat*, are the dominant undertaking, and they are what most of us mean by practising the religion. The other side, the one the Munajat describes, in which the believer seeks to know God

[1] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

and to come near Him, is often less practised. That side of the religion is called *ʿirfan*.

ʿIrfan is the Arabic name for what English books call Islamic mysticism, and the two words do not say the same thing. "Mysticism" suggests mystery, something hidden and hard to pin down. The Arabic word names a kind of knowing. It shares its root with *maʿrifah*, knowledge, and an *ʿarif* is, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "someone who knows".

The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is knowing Him from close, with the heart, which is what the Munajat asks for. In Murtada Mutahhari's words, the ʿarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[2]. ʿIrfan is that knowing, and the training of the soul that makes it possible. It is part of the Islam we already know: its sources are the Qur'an and the words of the Imams, and the prayer at the head of this page is one of them.

This book argues that this side of the religion is worth every believer's pursuit. ʿIrfan travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. It is rooted in the Qur'an and the Imams. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and to God Himself.

Who this book is for

The argument is addressed to anyone who prays, fasts, and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right; whether the religion has another dimension. No knowledge of ʿirfan, of philosophy, or of Arabic is assumed. The book is meant as a welcoming introduction to ʿirfan, a guide to beginning the journey that strives for brevity and clarity. Each chapter opens with a section that details some of the words you'll meet, along with an explanation; all terms are gathered in the glossary at the end. Additional call-out sections are spread throughout with helpful context and short side notes.

[2]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

How the book is built

The book is built in five parts. Each answers one question and depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters One to Three), asks why a believer should bother. It answers that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. The goal of ʿirfan is already on our lips in our duʿas.

Part Two, *Getting Ready* (Chapters Four to Seven), describes the landscape a traveller passes through on the journey towards ʿirfan: the self. It also sets out the boundary that keeps the traveller safe, the shariʿa, and the guide who walks alongside.

Part Three, *The Road* (Chapters Eight to Twelve), asks how the path is walked: through ordered stages, by repentance, discipline, and love, to the loss of the false self.

Part Four, *Fellow Travellers* (Chapters Thirteen to Fifteen), meets those who walked the road before us. It shows the road's roots in the Qur'an and the Imams, where its travellers arrived, and how Shia ʿirfan relates to Sufism.

Part Five, *The Destination* (Chapters Sixteen and Seventeen), asks what the road is for. The friends of God return to people, with God; every soul returns to God.

Where this book comes from

This book is inspired by a lecture series on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour. The content and structure of those lectures are the core of the book. Wherever the Sheikh is quoted directly, the words are his own, from that series.

Turning spoken lectures into a book has called for some editorial adaptation. To suit a wider readership, the book also adds context and explanation to support its main arguments. It draws on a wider literature as well: the words of the Imams in Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya, and the supplications of the Mafatih; then the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to modern scholars such as Mirza Jawad

Maliki Tabrizi, ʿAllama Tabataba'i, Imam Khomeini, and Ayatullah Mutahhari. Every source is given in a footnote, for readers who want to go further.

The finer questions of ʿirfan remain an ongoing conversation among our *ʿulama'*: whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, how far ordinary believers can travel. Where they differ, this book presents each view with neutrality.

What you can expect

Three guiding principles frame the discussions in the chapters that follow. The first is that ʿirfan is never pursued for the sake of powers, such as reading minds or foreseeing future events. Sheikh Bahmanpour and the wider literature agree on this, as Chapter One shows.

The second is that there is no separate sect or order through which ʿirfan must be gained. Shia ʿirfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam. How this position differs from that of the Sufi orders is explored in Chapter Fifteen.

The third principle is the most important: no part of the journey towards ʿirfan requires stepping outside the shariʿa, and nothing on that journey is gained by doing so. The beginning of ʿirfan, as the Sheikh puts it, is the shariʿa. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it; it is the law lived from the inside. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marjaʿ. A fear that mysticism might do exactly that is one reason some scholars have been wary of ʿirfan. Chapter Fourteen sets out their wider concerns, with the answers given to them.

By the end, a reader should feel able to say what ʿirfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path entail. For those who wish to go further, each chapter and the epilogue offer small, practical steps for bringing this into daily life alongside the wajibat.

PART ONE

The Call

Why travel?

The Qur’an invites more than the minimum: not only knowing about God, but knowing Him. That knowing is reached by purifying the heart, and our own prayers already ask for it.

1 · More than the minimum
2 · Knowing about God is not knowing Him
3 · You already know these words

إِلٰهِي لَمْ يَكُنْ لِي حَوْلٌ فَأَنْتَقِلَ بِهِ عَنْ مَعْصِيَتِكَ إِلاَّ فِي وَقْتٍ أَيْقَظْتَنِي لِمَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, I was not strong enough to move away from Your disobedience, except when You awakened me to Your love.

Munajat Sha‘baniyyah

1

More than the minimum

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

Qur'an 30:21

There is a verse often recited at weddings, one most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves "that you may take comfort in them", and that He ordained "affection and mercy" between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words above: this is a sign for a people who reflect. Whether a person sees it depends on something in the person doing the looking. That something, and why it is worth developing, is the subject of this chapter.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma'rifah*: knowledge of God · *'arif* (plural *'urafa'*): one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya' Allah*: the friends of God · *shirk*: setting up a partner beside God

What the minimum leaves out

Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due, and goes on hajj can hope for *jannah*, provided they do what is *wajib* and avoid what is forbidden. This claim is not contested. Sheikh Bahmanpour accepts it as fair for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point, describing the obligatory rules of fiqh as "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"[3].

The second claim goes further, and it is the one this book disputes. Some jurists and activists hold that the obligatory acts are the whole of the religion; anything beyond them, they say, is made up by the whims and wishes of certain mystics.

To see why there is more than the obligations, let's turn to the Qur'an and read on from the verse this chapter began with. Surah al-Rum names three more sets of signs: the creation of the heavens and the earth, with the variety of our languages and colours; our sleep and our work; the lightning, and the rain that revives the dead earth (Q 30:22–24). Each verse ends as the first did, by saying who the sign is for.

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

There are indeed signs in that for those who know.

Qur'an 30:22

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.

Qur'an 30:23

إِنَّ فِي ذَٰلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

There are indeed signs in that for people who exercise their reason.

Qur'an 30:24

[3]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

Four times in a row, the Qur'an makes the same point. The signs are all around us: in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work, in the weather. Yet they are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening, and reasoning is what the Qur'an asks of us beyond the minimum.

For the avoidance of doubt, this invitation from the Qur'an is not an invitation to circumvent the law or to abandon the prescribed wajibat. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"[4]. Within those bounds, the Qur'an is just as insistent, in these verses and others, that it invites us to more than the obligatory acts.

Signs most people miss

An invitation addressed to those who reflect, know, listen, and reason implies that many people do none of these things. This is not limited to the careless. Most pious people, even those careful about the shariʿa, do not find a sign in these verses. Looking at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

We have heard these verses many times, and we accept that there are signs in them because the Qur'an says so; yet accepting that a sign exists is not the same as perceiving it. The Qur'an describes the gap in one verse.

وَكَأَيِّن مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ ﴿١٠٥﴾

How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass by while they are disregardful of it!

Qur'an 12:105

ʿAllama Tabataba'i explains what passing by a sign means; a person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and "what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator"[5]. Most of us see only the lamp. We witness the rain as rain and the marriage as a marriage, and we pass them by without perceiving what they say about their Creator.

[4]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

[5]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.

The fault is in the receiver

If the signs are present and plain, and yet we still pass them by, the fault is on our side. The Qur'an says where it lies, speaking of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ ءَاذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَآ ۚ
أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ كَٱلْأَنْعَٰمِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray.

Qur'an 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. It is about what lies behind the senses. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things, whereas inside a human being there should be something more: a faculty, which animals lack, that turns what the senses take in into understanding. In most of us, it is not working.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is [rusted]." That machine is the soul. It has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. This is the whole subject in one sentence: mysticism is about making the soul hear, see, and reflect. It is not easy, and it requires a great deal of training.

Placing the fault in the receiver has two consequences. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs; we are failing to receive them.

The second is that the problem can be solved. A faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired; one that is absent cannot be made fit for purpose. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of 'Allama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part of the innate instincts of the human being"[6]. The longing for God, and the faculty that perceives Him, are part of how we are made.

[6] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 4.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, the journey begins, and it does not end; it is, in the Sheikh's words, a path that "has a beginning and no end".

Some do see

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it already works. The Qur'an describes them more than once. People can be divided into two groups: those whose souls work, and those whose souls do not. The first group are the *'urafa'*, the plural of *'arif*. The prophets and the Imams (as) are a class of their own; the 'urafa' are ordinary believers who see more than the rest. The first description of them is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا ٱلْمُؤْمِنُونَ ٱلَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ ٱللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned,

Qur'an 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of; a name means little to a person who does not know whom it names. The believers of this verse are thus the believers who know Allah. A verse in Surah Al 'Imran goes further, giving them another name.

شَهِدَ ٱللَّهُ أَنَّهُۥ لَآ إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَٱلْمَلَٰٓئِكَةُ وَأُو۟لُوا۟ ٱلْعِلْمِ

Allah ... bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Qur'an 3:18

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads "those who possess knowledge" as another name for the 'urafa'. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah. Our knowledge of *tawhid*, God's oneness, is still not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp; the intellect alone cannot reach its depths, and only the awakened soul can. Surah Fatir describes the same people by what they feel.

إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى ٱللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ ٱلْعُلَمَٰٓؤُا۟

Only those of Allah's servants having knowledge fear Him.

Qur'an 35:28

Most of us fear Allah's punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all.

Surah Yunus gives them another name: the *awliya' Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62). Imam ʿAli (as) describes what these friends see that others miss.

God's special devotees are those who perceive the world's reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.[7]

Nahj al-Balagha

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. This does not mean turning away from the world. There is nothing wrong with pursuing material wealth in this life; the trouble is being solely occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends, and a place in society, as we do. They think not about themselves but about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to all

The Qur'an also tells us what these people receive. The first gift is nearness: Surah al-Waqiʿa sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places the Foremost Ones.

وَٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ٱلسَّٰبِقُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ ٱلْمُقَرَّبُونَ ﴿١١﴾

And the Foremost Ones are the foremost ones: they are the ones brought near [to Allah],

Qur'an 56:10-11

[7] Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

The Arabic for “brought near” is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone; being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, so that they understand far more.

The second gift is a different kind of life, promised in Surah al-Nahl to whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith.

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَٰلِحًا مِّن ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهُۥ حَيَوٰةً طَيِّبَةً ۖ

Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life

Qur’an 16:97

This good life, *hayat tayyiba*, is a clean life. Its people live in the world without being soiled by it, rising above the worries that occupy everyone else. It is this good life that the mystics seek.

The third gift is peace, promised in the verse of Surah Yunus that names the friends of God.

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Qur’an 10:62

For the muqarrabun, the terms are entirely different from those of ordinary believers.

None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa’ answers that concern.

وَمَن يُطِعِ ٱللَّهَ وَٱلرَّسُولَ فَأُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ مَعَ ٱلَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ ٱللَّهُ عَلَيْهِم مِّنَ ٱلنَّبِيِّـۧنَ وَٱلصِّدِّيقِينَ وَٱلشُّهَدَآءِ وَٱلصَّٰلِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُو۟لَٰٓئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Qur'an 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada'*, which the translation used here renders "martyrs" and which he takes as "the witnesses"; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks are beyond us; the fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and from among them God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

That doorway is open to people like us: ordinary people can also enter the realm of the muqarrabun. It is difficult, but it is open, because we are made for it. We call ourselves human beings, yet, in the Sheikh's words, "we are not yet human beings". We begin with the potential to become human in the full sense that the prophets are. He means this as a statement of what we were made for. A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God; God created us with that capacity, and wants us to reach it.

This is the case for pursuing 'irfan. The Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. That rank is open to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

The aim is God, not powers

Pursuing 'irfan means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul in an attempt to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, or to master the hidden world of the soul. This kind of mysticism must be held apart from the real thing. Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and see.

Sheikh Bahmanpour ended his first lecture more strongly. ʿIrfan "is not about any type of power or empowering the soul" to work *karamat* and *muʿjizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: "These are shirk." *Shirk*, setting up a partner beside God, is the gravest charge in Islam.

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. ʿAllama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he "has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities", nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so "does not move on the path of the Beloved's pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God". It is his own self that he worships, "though he may not admit it by word of mouth"[8].

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: ʿALLAMA TABATABA'I**
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> Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba'i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Qur'an in twenty volumes[9]. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown "with the two wings of knowledge and action". He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he "came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur'an"[10]. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani's record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba'i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50[11]. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*[12], from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"[13].

[8] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.
[9] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.
[10] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 8.
[11] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.
[12] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.
[13] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The ʻurafa', he writes, consider it "a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one's goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself", and he recalls Imam ʻAli (as) saying that he worshipped God not from fear of His Fire or desire for His Paradise but because he found Him worthy of worship[14].

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Mutahhari also explains why seeking them would be shirk: the goal has become something other than God.

Seeking, and nothing else

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first lecture: ʻirfan "is actually seeking and nothing else". It seeks two things: *maʻrifah*, the knowledge of God; and the love of God.

> ع **WORD STUDY: ʻIRFAN AND MAʻRIFAH**
> *ʻIrfan*, *maʻrifah*, *ʻarif* and its plural *ʻurafa'* belong to one family of words about knowing. An ʻarif, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is "someone who knows". "Mystic" is used of Christians, Hindus, and Buddhists alike; ʻarif is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The ʻarif "wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it"[15]. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), says that there is no way to God except through knowledge[16]. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter Two.

ʻAllama Tabataba'i's definition agrees: "The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him"[17].

ʻIrfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what kind of knowing is that?

[14] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.
[15] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.
[16] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʻa), p. 9.
[17] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

➤ TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen, and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.

2

Knowing about God is not knowing Him

On a day of fasting in Ramadan, by late afternoon, no one has to be told that they are hungry. They do not read it in a book or work it out from the clock. The hunger is known from the inside. Sheikh Bahmanpour uses hunger to describe a kind of knowing that differs from the kind gained by study.

Most of what we know of God is of the kind gained by study. We learn the rulings of fiqh, the beliefs the scholars set out, and the history of the Prophet ﷺ and the Imams (as); all of it is knowledge about God. Chapter One argued that the Qur'an invites more than the minimum, and that the aim is to know and love God. The 'knowing' it refers to is the kind of knowing that a fasting person has of their hunger: knowing God directly, and not only knowing about Him.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *'ilm*: knowledge, especially knowledge gained by study · *'ilm al-husuli*: acquired knowledge · *'ilm al-huduri*: knowledge by presence · *'aql*: the reasoning intellect · *suluk*: wayfaring; the path of purification

Knowing about, and knowing

Let's start with the two kinds of knowing. The first is acquired knowledge, *'ilm al-husuli*. It reaches us from outside, through the senses or by reasoning.

We form concepts of the things around us and then analyse those concepts. Almost everything we learn from teachers and books is of this kind.

Acquired knowledge works by defining its object. To understand a thing, we sort it into a category and mark where it ends and something else begins. The Arabic for a definition, *hadd*, also means a limit: to define a thing is to limit it. The old definition of a human being as "the rational animal" works by drawing a line round us.

The second kind is knowledge by presence, *'ilm al-huduri*. It does not come from outside and needs no concept to carry it; it is with the soul already. The plainest case is our knowledge of our own self. Hunger, the example this chapter opened with, is another, and so are pain and anxiety. Anxiety has a cause outside us, yet the feeling itself arises inside the soul.

Knowledge by presence is complete in a way that acquired knowledge is not. When the body is hungry, the soul knows it at once and without effort, and nothing of the hunger is missed. The Sheikh adds that the hunger may even be false, and yet what is felt is real. A person who has eaten enough can still feel hungry. They may be wrong to think that their body needs food. They cannot be wrong that they feel hungry.

Knowledge by presence is what the mystics are after. Sheikh Bahmanpour defines mysticism as the urge to reach out to the infinite through knowledge by presence. The two kinds of knowing aim at different things: *'ilm* aims at understanding, and *ma'rifah* aims at arriving. A person does not try to understand their hunger; they arrive at it and feel it. In the same way, the mystic's aim is to arrive at God and not to define Him, since a God who has been defined has been limited.

Imam Khomeini records the same distinction, citing the view that a gnostic of God "knows God through direct witnessing", while a scholar of God "attains the knowledge of God through philosophical proofs"[18].

> ع **WORD STUDY: 'ILM AL-HUSULI AND 'ILM AL-HUDURI**
>
> *Husul* means acquiring or obtaining, whereas *hudur* means presence. In *'ilm al-husuli*, acquired knowledge, what reaches the mind is a concept or an image of

[18] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 542.

the thing, while the thing itself stays outside. In *ʿilm al-huduri*, knowledge by presence, the thing known is itself present to the soul, as our own self, our hunger, and our pain are present. Imam Khomeini's word for the gnostic's witnessing, *huduriyya*, comes from the same root. The religious texts use *ʿilm* and *maʿrifah* for the same thing; this book keeps them apart only to make the two kinds of knowing easier to see. Chapter One's Word Study noted that there is no way to God except through knowledge, and left open what type of knowledge it refers to; it assuredly refers to knowledge by presence.

Where reason stops

Acquired knowledge is the work of reason, *ʿaql*, the faculty by which we understand and argue. Reason has a limit. When we know a thing, we know its attributes: its colour, its size, and what it does. Every description says that it is brown or square or useful, and none says what the "it" is. Ibn Sina, the greatest of the Muslim philosophers, granted this. The reality of things, he held, is beyond the reach of human reason.

If this is true of the things around us, it is true far more of God. God has no colour or size for the mind to take hold of, and no boundary for a definition to draw. Imam ʿAli (as) says as much at the opening of the first oration in *Nahj al-Balagha*, where he praises God.

> *Soaring thoughts cannot reach him and deep minds cannot fathom him.*[19]
>
> Nahj al-Balagha

The Imam's two images, soaring and depth, name the two strengths of reason, its range and its penetration, and neither arrives at God. The next sentence of the oration gives the reason. God, it says, "cannot be described, for he is beyond the limits of demarcated boundaries"[20].

What reason can do, it does. It can show that God exists, and it can say what He is not: He is not a body, He is not in one place and absent from another, and He has no partner. All of this is knowledge about God, and all of it is

[19]Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.
[20]Imam ʿAli, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.1.1.

negative knowledge: each statement says what God is not, and none says what He is.

ʿIrfan asks for the positive side, to know God as the Merciful, the Compassionate, and the Forgiving. The names can be learned from a book. To know God as Merciful from within, as a hungry person knows their hunger, is knowledge by presence, and we have knowledge by presence only of what is within us: our own self and some of its states. Mulla Sadra held that knowledge by presence is the only way to know the reality of anything, God above all. If God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must happen within the soul.

A sense of God already lives in the soul, however faint. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls it a vague idea of God that we carry inside us. Mostly we do not notice it. The answer to how God can be known therefore lies in the soul, which most of us have hardly begun to know.

◈ WHO'S WHO: MULLA SADRA AND THE SCHOOLS OF PHILOSOPHY

Mulla Sadra died in 1050/1640[21]. Before him, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's account, Islamic philosophy had two main schools, the Peripatetic, *al-hikma al-mashsha'iyya*, and the Illuminationist. The Peripatetic school is the way of reasoned proof that Murtada Mutahhari describes: the philosopher works with "reason, deductions and proofs"[22]. It is the school of Ibn Sina. Mulla Sadra called his own philosophy neither of these but the transcendent philosophy, *al-hikma al-mutaʿaliya*. He took what the mystics know only by experience and gave it rational argument, a rationalised mysticism, and held that the reality of things is known only through knowledge by presence. Put simply, the Peripatetics reason their way to the truth, whereas Mulla Sadra held that reasoning must end in the soul's own presence to what it knows. He studied the ʿirfan of Ibn ʿArabi deeply without belonging to any Sufi order, and rated Ibn ʿArabi above Ibn Sina[23]. *Kernel of the Kernels* records that after a lifetime in philosophy he became absorbed in worship and the purification of his inner being, until "it became clear to me that their syllogisms were barren and their path devoid of straightness"[24].

[21] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 40.
[22] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.
[23] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 35, 40.
[24] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 7.

Light in the heart

Knowledge that cannot be produced from analysis, and that has to be found within the soul, must be placed there. A hadith on knowledge, which Imam Khomeini quotes in his *Forty Hadith*, says by whom.

> *Knowledge is not extensive learning. Rather, it is a light that God casts in the heart of whomever He wills.*[25]
>
> Hadith

The hadith sets the two kinds of knowing side by side. Extensive learning is acquired knowledge, gathered from outside. The light is not gathered at all; God places it in the heart.

The words “whomever He wills” raise a question: does God keep His light for a chosen few? Sheikh Bahmanpour speaks of the light differently, and he does so with a verse of Surah al-Nur.

ٱللَّهُ نُورُ ٱلسَّمَٰوَٰتِ وَٱلْأَرْضِ ۚ

> *Allah is the Light of the heavens and the earth.*
>
> Qur’an 24:35

Allah’s light is everywhere, in the heavens and in the earth, and He is with us wherever we are. The hadith and the verse can seem to pull in different directions: the hadith says that God casts the light into the heart of whomever He wills, as if He chose some hearts over others, whereas the verse says that His light is everywhere already.

Both are true. The lighting of any heart is God’s act, as the hadith says. Yet God does not choose some people for the light and pass over others. His light is everywhere and nothing is held back on His side. What keeps a heart dark is that it is closed, and the work of the ‘urafa’ is to open it to a light that was always there.

Imam Khomeini explains why purifying the heart matters so much. When the soul is purified, he writes, divine teaching follows, “for there is no niggard-

[25] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

liness in the higher realms, which are bounteous by necessity"[26]. He grounds this in a promise of Surah al-Baqarah.

وَٱتَّقُواْ ٱللَّهَ ۖ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ ٱللَّهُ ۗ

Be wary of Allah and Allah will teach you.

Qur'an 2:282

In the verse, God's teaching follows on from wariness of Him. Sheikh Bahmanpour puts the same order as light and darkness: the light comes to the hearts of the pure, and darkness covers the impure. Chapter One reached the same conclusion by a different road. Surah al-Rum says that God's signs are for those who reflect, know, listen, and reason, and yet most people pass them by. Nothing in the signs is hidden and nothing is wrong with our eyes; the fault lies with an inner faculty that has rusted and does not receive.

A light received in one heart can reach another. The knowledge of books passes from mind to mouth, through speech and writing, whereas the knowledge of the 'urafa' passes, in the Sheikh's words, "from heart to heart". Receiving it directly from God is possible but difficult, and most travellers begin through someone who has already received it. Chapter Seven returns to that companion.

The path is purification

If the light is everywhere and the heart is closed, the path to knowing God is the opening of the heart. Two words name the difference. Knowledge learned at a university or a seminary comes through *fikr*, thought: we think, put things together, analyse, and find out. Knowledge of God comes through *suluk*, wayfaring, which the Sheikh describes as the path to purity.

In the Sheikh's words, "You purify yourself and then wait for Allah to put the light in your heart." This waiting is not for an absent light. It is the patience of a heart that has done its part and leaves the rest to God.

Purification begins with the shari'a. Its first step is to polish the soul by doing whatever the Prophet ﷺ has asked, and without this there is no ma'ri-

[26]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 331.

fah. The Qur'an calls the believers to answer Allah and the Apostle when he summons them to what will give them life (Q 8:24). That life comes when a person follows the Prophet completely.

Practice depends on knowing what to practise, and this is where study comes in. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, places it at the start. The first essential for the traveller, he says, is knowledge of the rules of the shariʿa, learned from a jurist. The traveller puts that knowledge into practice and persists until conviction and gnosis grow by degrees, "for knowledge gives birth to action and action in turn brings knowledge"[27]. Learning starts the circle, practice purifies the heart, and the purified heart receives a deeper knowledge, which leads to better practice.

Imam Khomeini gives study its place, with a warning. A learning that does not bring faith with it, he writes, "is the greatest of veils"; yet "one has to approach a veil in order to tear it into shreds"[28].

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah ties the light to the path in one line.

إِنَّ مَنِ ٱنْتَهَجَ بِكَ لَمُسْتَنِيرٌ

One who follows Your path is enlightened.[29]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The prologue opened on a line from this prayer that asks for the eyes of the heart to be lit until they reach the source of God's grandeur. This line names who receives that light: the one who follows God's path.

STORY: THE PHILOSOPHER AND THE ʿARIF

Murtada Mutahhari records a meeting between Ibn Sina and Abu Saʿid ibn Abi al-Khayr, one of the most famous of all the ʿurafa'. Abu Saʿid was preaching on the necessity of deeds, and on obedience and disobedience to God. Ibn Sina answered him with a quatrain (a poem of four lines). Wherever God's favour and grace are found, it ran, "Let the not-done be like the done, the done like the not-done." The verse leaned on God's forgiveness in place of deeds. Abu Saʿid

[27] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 56.
[28] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 403.
[29] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §88.

replied at once with a quatrain of his own, which ends: "Do not rely on forgiveness, for never / Was the not-done like the done, the done like the not-done"[30]. The ʿarif would not let a verse, however well turned, take the place of deeds. Mutahhari adds that towards the end of his life Ibn Sina "developed mystic inclinations"[31].

Knowing by drawing near

Those brought near to God, the ʿurafa', know Him by presence, through a veil removed and not a definition learned. Their knowing is present to the soul, as hunger is present to the one who fasts, and it comes as a light that God gives to a purified heart. Knowing God therefore differs in kind from knowing about God. It is reached by purification; study, in the view of Imam Khomeini and ʿAllama Tabataba'i, serves it but cannot replace it.

Where, then, does an ordinary believer already stand on this path?

➤ TRY THIS

In every prostration of the daily prayer we say, "Glory belongs to my Lord, the Exalted, and Him do I praise." ʿAllama Tabataba'i uses these words to show how knowledge follows action[32]. For one week, in one prayer each day, say them slowly, "believing it to be a fact". Notice your own lowliness with your forehead on the ground, then the majesty of the One you are calling exalted. From "a very minor action, such as this dhikr said in prostration", he says, a person comes to discover God's absolute majesty[33].

[30] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 29.

[31] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 42.

[32] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 56–57.

[33] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 57.

3

You already know these words

وَّقَلْبِي بِحُبِّكَ مُتَيَّماً

And my heart enthralled by Your love![34]

Du'a Kumayl

These words come near the end of Du'a Kumayl, the prayer Imam 'Ali (as) taught to Kumayl ibn Ziyad, one of his closest disciples. The Mafatih al-Jinan recommends it on every Thursday evening, the night before Friday, when many of us hear it[35]. The line asks God for a heart enthralled by His love.

A request for God's love begins to answer the question Chapter Two ended on. That chapter argued that knowing God is reached by purifying the heart, and it asked where an ordinary believer already stands on this path. Du'a Kumayl asks for the love that goes with that knowing, and other prayers we recite ask for the knowing itself. This chapter sets out what they ask for.

[34] *Du'a Kumayl* (duas.org), §221.

[35] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *duʿa*: supplication, any request made to God · *munajat*: an intimate, whispered prayer to God · *Mafatih al-Jinan*: the standard manual of Shia prayers · *inqitaʿ*: severance of the heart from all but God

Cut off from all else

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah as a sequence. Those who seek God want to know Him and to look at Him, but "they have to cut off from everything first". In the prayer, the request for light in the eyes of the heart, with which this book opened, follows straight on from a request to be cut off.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي كَمَالَ ٱلاِنْقِطَاعِ إِلَيْكَ

My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relations with everything else[36]

Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah

The Arabic word for this severance is *inqitaʿ*, being cut off, and the Munajat asks for it in full. Taken at its word, the request could sound like a call to leave family, work, and society behind. The prayers themselves rule that reading out.

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, recited on the nights of Ramadan, names exactly what is to be cut away. "O my Master, (please) expel love for the world out of my heart," it asks (سَيِّدِي أَخْرِجْ حُبَّ ٱلدُّنْيَا مِنْ قَلْبِي)[37]. What the prayer asks to lose is the heart's love for the world, not the world itself, nor the people and the work in it.

Chapter One met the same severance in the friends of God. They keep their families, their friends, and their place in society, as we do; it is their hearts that are cut off from everything but God. The severance the prayers ask for is therefore in the heart, not in the household or the marketplace.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, describes this severance from the other side, as something God has already done for those He loves.

[36] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah* (duas.org), §104.

[37] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §384.

وَأَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَزَلْتَ ٱلأَغْيَارَ عَنْ قُلُوبِ أَحِبَّائِكَ حَتَّىٰ لَمْ يُحِبُّوا سِوَاكَ

It is You Who have removed love for others from the hearts of Your lovers so that they have loved none save You[38]

Duʿa ʿArafah

In these hearts the severance is God's own work, and it leaves nothing behind but love for Him.

To see, to love, to draw near

A heart cleared of everything but God is free for Him. The prayers go on to ask for three things: to see God with the heart, to love Him, and to come near Him.

The first is sight. The Munajat asks God to light the eyes of the heart so that they look at Him, and pass even through the veils of light. The Sheikh raises the difficulty himself: the Qur'an says that sight cannot perceive God (Q 6:103), and some who meet these words take them for a mistake.

Later in the course he answers that the eyes cannot catch Him, and the heart can, which agrees with the verse. Our physical eyes work perfectly well, and still we miss God's signs, because the inner faculty behind them is blind. The prayer asks God to give that inner faculty, the eye of the heart, light to see by.

Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, speaks of that light as something God has already lit in the hearts of His friends.

أَنْتَ ٱلَّذِي أَشْرَقْتَ ٱلأَنْوَارَ فِي قُلُوبِ أَوْلِيَائِكَ

It is You Who have lit the illuminations in the hearts of Your intimate servants[39]

Duʿa ʿArafah

The word translated "Your intimate servants" is *awliya'*, the friends of God whom Chapter One met in Surah Yunus. Chapter Two described a light that

[38] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §783–784.
[39] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §781.

is everywhere and that a purified heart receives. This line says the same from the side of prayer: the lighting of any heart is God's act.

The second request is love. The Munajat asks for a place among God's friends, and it defines that place by love.

إِلٰهِي أَقِمْنِي فِي أَهْلِ وِلايَتِكَ مُقَامَ مَنْ رَجَا ٱلزِّيَادَةَ مِنْ مَحَبَّتِكَ

My Lord, place me among Your friends in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love.[40]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

The Sheikh reads the friendship asked for here, *wilaya*, as having two parts. One is ma'rifah: understanding God, looking at Him, and knowing Him. The other is love for Him, which is incessant, while the ma'rifah keeps increasing. These are the two aims Chapter One gave 'irfan, and both are in one line of the Munajat.

The third request is nearness, and the Munajat makes it earlier in the same prayer.

إِلٰهِي هَبْ لِي قَلْباً يُدْنِيهِ مِنْكَ شَوْقُهُ

My Lord, provide me with a heart, the passion of which may bring it near You[41]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

In this request the heart is brought near by its own passion for God. Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali goes further and asks to love the meeting with God itself. "O Lord of Glory and Honor, (please do) make me love meeting You," it says (يَا ذَا ٱلْجَلَالِ وَٱلْإِكْرَامِ حَبِّبْ إِلَيَّ لِقَاءَكَ)[42].

[40] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §92–93.

[41] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §82.

[42] *Du'a Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §599.

The Whispered Prayer of the Lovers, one of the fifteen whispered prayers printed with the Sahifa, asks for a place among those who have already been brought near.

> *My God, place us with him whom Thou hast chosen for Thy nearness and Thy friendship, ... granted gazing upon Thy face*[43]
>
> Whispered Prayer of the Lovers

For some of us, calling on God can feel like calling into the sky to someone far away. For others, God is present when they call, and they feel His response. The prayer asks for a place among the second.

A pupil reading above his level

Requests this high raise a difficulty, and Sheikh Bahmanpour states it himself. These words belong to the peak of the understanding and longing of the *muqarrabun*, those brought near to God, and he asks why we are told to recite them at all. Telling ordinary believers to say them, he says, is "like [telling] a primary school boy to read books of university".

The prayers themselves speak from need, as a pupil would. Duʿa ʿArafah, as given in the Mafatih, comes to God with nothing to offer but its need of Him.

> هَا أَنَا أَتَوَسَّلُ إِلَيْكَ بِفَقْرِي إِلَيْكَ
>
> *Here I am begging You by my need for You.*[44]
>
> Duʿa ʿArafah

Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali makes the same plea, and places the one who prays at a door. "O my Master, I, Your servant, am standing at Your door owing to neediness," it says (سَيِّدِي عَبْدُكَ بِبَابِكَ أَقَامَتْهُ اَلْخَصَاصَةُ بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ)[45]. Need is the only reason this line gives for coming.

The line at the head of Part One takes this humility further. In it the Munajat admits that the one reciting had no strength to move away from dis-

[43] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.
[44] Imam al-Husayn, *Duʿa ʿArafah* (duas.org), §689.
[45] *Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali* (duas.org), §510.

obedience "except when You awakened me to Your love"[46]. Even the turning towards God is His doing.

The answer to the difficulty rests on the same humility. We do not understand many of the meanings of these words, which are above our level, yet not understanding them does not make them meaningless. We are honoured by the invitation to recite them, and if the reciter is sincere, God may grant the request, as He granted the Imams what they asked.

> **ع WORD STUDY: DUʿA AND MUNAJAT**
> *Duʿa* is the general word for supplication: any request addressed to God, in any words. A *munajat* is one kind of duʿa. The Mafatih's English calls the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah a "confidential prayer"[47], and William Chittick translates the fifteen munajat printed with the Sahifa as "whispered prayers"[48]. Both translations describe speech meant for God alone. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi explains why the Imams' supplications reach further than their other words. In their narrations they spoke with people, whereas in their supplications they spoke with God, and the level of speech depends on the understanding of the one addressed. The Qur'an, he writes, is a "Descending-Qur'an", God's words to His servants. The supplications are an "Ascending-Qur'an", the words of His most distinguished servants rising towards Him[49].

Prayers for ordinary nights

God's invitation to recite these words comes through books that ordinary believers already use. Four of the prayers quoted in this chapter are in the Mafatih al-Jinan, the standard manual of Shia devotion[50]. The Mafatih sets each of them on a night or a day in the believer's year.

The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah is listed among the acts of the month of Shaʿban. The Mafatih gives a report that calls it the confidential prayer of Imam ʿAli (as) and the Imams, which they used to say in that month[51]. It adds that it is "advisable to say it with presence of heart all the time"[52].

[46] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 164.
[47] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[48] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[49] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.
[50] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[51] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 243.
[52] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.

The other prayers have their own times. Duʿa Kumayl belongs to Thursday evenings and to the night of mid-Shaʿban[53]. Duʿa ʿArafah is the prayer of Imam al-Husayn (as) on the Day of ʿArafah[54]. Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali belongs to Ramadan; Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as) said it in the last hour of the month's nights[55]. Maliki Tabrizi tells the traveller not to forget it, every night or every other night[56].

These nights make the words familiar, and Imam Khomeini could count on it. "You are already familiar with the words used in Imams' supplications," he told his listeners, before reading them lines from the Shaʿbaniyyah[57].

⧗ HISTORY: THE MAFATIH AND THE SAHIFA

The *Mafatih al-Jinan*, "Keys to the Heavens", gathers the supplications of the Imams, the words to be recited at particular times, and the forms for visiting the Imams' shrines. Its compiler, Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, was a scholar of vast learning who died in Najaf in 1359/1940[58]. Al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya is far older. William Chittick calls it "the oldest prayer manual in Islamic sources", composed by Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin (as), the fourth Imam; Shia tradition ranks it behind only the Qur'an and Nahj al-Balagha[59]. The Imam died in Medina in 95/713–4, or a year earlier[60]. The fifteen whispered prayers, the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers among them, were added to several modern editions of the Sahifa. They seem to have reached most Shia through ʿAllama Muhammad Baqir Majlisi, the compiler of *Bihar al-Anwar*[61].

Familiarity with the words is not the same as reaching what they describe. Maliki Tabrizi, having called the supplications an Ascending-Qur'an, writes that this "is not accepted and comprehended by any one, except a small number of believers who are thoroughly familiar and enlightened"[62].

Sheikh Bahmanpour still recommends the Munajat to every listener, to be recited in Shaʿban as often as they can. The two positions answer different

[53] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 129.
[54] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 374.
[55] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 282.
[56] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 111.
[57] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 156.
[58] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 112.
[59] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 7.
[60] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 8.
[61] Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 9.
[62] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 43.

questions. Maliki Tabrizi speaks of how far a reciter reaches; the Sheikh speaks of who may begin. What this chapter claims is access to these words, rather than attainment of what they ask for.

Words already on our lips

Access to these words is where an ordinary believer already stands on the path. Part One began with the Qur'an's invitation to more than the minimum, and Chapter Two showed that the more is knowing God, not only knowing about Him, reached by purifying the heart. The Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, Duʿa Kumayl, Duʿa Abu Hamza al-Thumali, and Duʿa ʿArafah ask for that same knowing and the love that goes with it: they ask God to cut the heart off from all else, to light it, to fill it with His love, and to bring it near.

They ask in the voice of someone in need, on nights the ordinary believer keeps. The goal of ʿirfan is therefore not foreign to the believer: it is already on our lips. The full text of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah, in Arabic and English, is given in the Appendix.

These prayers keep asking God to work on the heart and the self. What is this self?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> This week, read the petitions of the Munajat Shaʿbaniyyah from §82 to §111 (in the Appendix) once, slowly, with the English beside the Arabic. The Mafatih advises saying the prayer "with presence of heart"[63]. As you read, notice the requests this chapter has followed: to be cut off from all else, to see, to love, and to draw near. When Shaʿban comes, follow the Sheikh's own advice and recite the whole prayer "as much as you can".

[63] Shaykh ʿAbbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 245.

PART TWO

Getting Ready

What do I need before I set out?

The road to God runs through our own self, which is deeper than it looks. The shariʻa is its boundary from the first step to the last, and a tested guide walks beside the traveller, under the Imam, never in his place.

4 · Know yourself, know your Lord
5 · The soul and its worlds
6 · No path outside the law
7 · Finding a guide

فَقَدْ هَرَبْتُ إِلَيْكَ وَوَقَفْتُ بَيْنَ يَدَيْكَ مُسْتَكِيناً
لَكَ مُتَضَرِّعاً إِلَيْكَ

I have come running to You and am standing before You imploring You in humility.

Munajat Shaʻbaniyyah

4

Know yourself, know your Lord

In the month of Sha'ban, many of us recite the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, and early in the prayer comes a confession.

قَدْ جُرْتُ عَلَىٰ نَفْسِي فِي ٱلنَّظَرِ لَهَا

I have been unjust to my soul for I have not looked after it.[64]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

The prayer offers these words as a "confession of my sins", and most of us say them in that spirit[65]. They also say something about the soul: it was given to us to look after, and it can be neglected.

That neglected soul is where the theory of 'irfan begins. Chapter Two argued that if God is to be known, and not only known about, the knowing must be found within our own soul, because the soul is the one place where we know anything from the inside. Chapter Three ended on the prayers' repeated requests that God work on the heart and the self. This chapter sets out what

[64]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 163; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §32.

[65]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 163.

the self is to someone who seeks God, and why the road to God runs through it.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *nafs*: the soul or self · *ruh*: the spirit; the higher soul · *liqa' Allah*: the meeting, or encounter, with God · *qurb*: nearness to God · *hijab* (plural *hujub*): a veil between the heart and God

The instrument of all knowing

'Irfan has a practical side and a theoretical side. The practical side is the training by which the mystics come to see, whereas the theoretical side sets out what they have seen as an account of existence, the soul, and the world, argued much as philosophy is argued. When Sheikh Bahmanpour turns to the theory, he begins with the soul, "because this is the means to understand and to learn".

Whatever else we come to know, we know with the soul, the inner faculty that Chapter One found rusted and in need of repair. Before anything else can be studied, the instrument itself has to be understood: how it works and what it can do.

The soul is also the one thing we know from the inside. Chapter Two called this knowledge by presence, *'ilm al-huduri*: knowing that needs no concept, because what is known is already present, as hunger is present to the one who fasts. The images in our minds are known in this way, because the soul holds them within itself, and whatever the mystics come to know by their practice, they know in the same way.

The soul's knowledge of itself goes one step further. Here the one who perceives and the thing perceived are the same, since the soul perceives itself, and this is the clearest case of knowledge by presence there is.

The Qur'an gives this instrument great weight. Surah al-Shams swears by the soul and by Him who fashioned it and "inspired it with [discernment between] its virtues and vices" (Q 91:7–8). The soul comes with the means to tell good from evil, and the next two verses say what follows from it.

قَدۡ أَفۡلَحَ مَن زَكَّىٰهَا ﴿٩﴾ وَقَدۡ خَابَ مَن دَسَّىٰهَا ﴿١٠﴾

one who purifies it is felicitous, and one who betrays it fails.

Qur'an 91:9-10

Success and failure both rest on what is done with the soul. The whole story of a human being in this world is therefore the story of the soul: we are here to develop it, and to fashion it as we choose. The Munajat's confession names the failure the surah describes, a soul not looked after, and the surah's word for looking after it is purifying.

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: MIRZA MUHAMMAD ʿALI SHAHABADI**
>
> Mirza Muhammad ʿAli Shahabadi was the teacher who most shaped Imam Khomeini's spiritual life. The Imam calls him *shaykhuna*, "our shaykh", and their relationship "was that of a murid with his murshid", a disciple with his spiritual guide[66]. Shahabadi taught a few chosen students the *Fusus al-Hikam* of Ibn ʿArabi, one of the most demanding books of mystical theory[67]. For the care of the soul, however, he sent them to the Qur'an. He told them to attend constantly to the closing verses of Surah al-Hashr, which begin by telling every soul to consider what it sends ahead for tomorrow (Q 59:18). Reciting them, he said, is "very effective for curing the soul and for holding the mischief of the self and Satan at bay"[68].

Forgetting God, forgetting ourselves

If the human story is the soul's story, losing sight of the soul is the deepest loss, and Surah al-Hashr names what causes it.

وَلَا تَكُونُواْ كَٱلَّذِينَ نَسُواْ ٱللَّهَ فَأَنسَىٰهُمۡ أَنفُسَهُمۡۚ أُوْلَٰٓئِكَ هُمُ ٱلۡفَٰسِقُونَ ﴿١٩﴾

Do not be like those who forget Allah, so He makes them forget their own souls. It is they who are the transgressors.

Qur'an 59:19

The verse makes the forgetting of the soul follow from the forgetting of God. Sheikh Bahmanpour counts most of us, ordinary Muslims included, among

[66] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.
[67] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.
[68] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 201.

those who have forgotten their souls. He does not mean that we will be punished for it. He means that we do not realise the potential our souls hold, and so do not develop them as we could.

The mystics draw a remedy from the same verse. If forgetting God makes us forget the soul, then remembering God turns our attention back to it. In their reading, it is only by remembering God that a person comes to attend to their own soul at all, and the return happens in stages. At first a person turns back to the self and believes that it has a Creator. A full knowledge of the soul comes later, through the remembrance of God, *dhikr*.

Surah al-An'am ties the two together from the other side, beginning with the soul.

ٱلَّذِينَ خَسِرُوٓاْ أَنفُسَهُمۡ فَهُمۡ لَا يُؤۡمِنُونَ ﴿٢٠﴾

Those who have ruined their souls will not have faith.

Qur'an 6:20

A ruined soul loses faith because a soul that is seen points to its Maker. The body is a composition of parts, and a person can suppose that matter assembled it by itself. The soul is not like that: as soon as it is seen, its Creator is seen, since it cannot have come about by chance. The theories that put everything down to chance arise, in the lectures' account, because people cannot see their own souls.

Forgetting runs in both directions, and so does knowing. A saying handed down from the Prophet ﷺ, and from Imam 'Ali (as), puts it in a single line.

من عرف نفسه فقد عرف ربه

Whoever knows his own self knows his Lord.[69]

Hadith

One meaning the lectures give the saying is that the soul reflects its Maker, so that to look into it is to learn of Him. The qualities in God are infinite and differ greatly from those in the soul, yet there is a likeness, and through that

[69] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 9; M. S. Bahmanpour, lecture slides.

likeness God can be known by looking within. The soul carries something of the spirit, *ruh*, that God breathed into the first human being (Q 15:29), and that spirit is not God but a spirit He created.

ʿAllama Tabataba'i draws the practical conclusion from a verse that tells believers to take care of their own souls (Q 5:105). The seeker, he writes, learns from it that the only path of perfect guidance is knowing himself, and that he "must see Allah through the window of his own soul"[70].

> **ع WORD STUDY: WHOEVER KNOWS HIMSELF**
> The saying is short in Arabic: *man ʿarafa nafsahu faqad ʿarafa rabbahu*. Its verb, *ʿarafa*, to know, shares its root with maʿrifah and ʿirfan, and its *nafs* is the word for the soul that Surah al-Shams swears by. Mohammad Ali Shomali writes that "it is difficult to find a book on ethics (Akhlaq), which has not quoted it"[71]. The tradition hands it down by two routes. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as), gives it as the words of the Prophet ﷺ[72], and ʿAllama Tabataba'i also cites it from the Prophet[73]. Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi quotes it as a narration from Imam ʿAli (as), as the lectures do: "Whoever has identified his self in reality has recognised his Creator"[74]. His wording adds "in reality". The self meant is the soul as it is, which those given God's grace come to see by removing "the material curtain from his spirit and self"[75].

Near already: meeting, not grasping

If God is known through the soul, the meeting with Him that the Qur'an promises passes through the soul as well. Surah al-Anʿam warns those who deny it.

قَدْ خَسِرَ ٱلَّذِينَ كَذَّبُوا۟ بِلِقَآءِ ٱللَّهِ ۖ

They are certainly losers who deny the encounter with Allah.

Qur'an 6:31

[70] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 7.
[71] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, pp. 8–9.
[72] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 9.
[73] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 7.
[74] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 125.
[75] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 125.

The encounter in this verse is *liqa' Allah*, the meeting with God, which every soul will come to, the believer and the unbeliever alike. Sheikh Bahmanpour explains the meeting through the soul. In it, "We remove the layers that cover our soul", and each of us will see the soul exactly as it is, with all the veils removed.

What is seen at that meeting is the soul, and the soul is a reflection of God. Seeing it is therefore seeing a reflection of God, and not God Himself. The verse still speaks of meeting Him, and not of meeting our own soul: the believer will perceive His mercy and reward, whereas the unbeliever will perceive His justice.

A difficulty follows. If whoever knows his own self knows his Lord, and the soul knows itself by presence, it could seem that God might be known completely from within. The soul cannot hold God as it holds the images in the mind, because He is without limit, and the soul's own depth shows the same thing from the other side. Even our own soul cannot be known to its depths, because it is too deep and too vast. If the soul cannot be known completely, still less can its Lord. Some understanding of God is possible through the soul, whereas a complete knowledge of Him is not.

The saying has been read both ways for this reason. Some read it as a denial: no one can know their own soul completely, so no one can know their Lord. The lectures allow that reading but prefer the other, and set beside the saying narrations which show that it speaks of a knowledge that is possible.

Imam Khomeini sets the same limit on the meeting. Those who hold that liqa' Allah is open to the seeker do not mean, he writes, "that it is permissible to fathom the mystery of the Divine Essence"[76]. If the Essence cannot be fathomed, what the meeting brings is a nearness, *qurb*, and never a grasp of Him.

Nearness to God is not a distance to be travelled. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, "We are actually in his presence at the moment. However, he is not in our presence." The soul stands before God now. What it lacks is the perception of the One before whom it stands. One day, the lectures say, He will become present to it.

[76]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 398.

The journey to God, then, covers no distance. It removes what covers the heart: the veils, *hujub*, that keep it from perceiving the One who is already near. Chapter One met this idea in the word *muqarrabun*, those brought near to God, and found that being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, since God is not far from anyone. The prologue's line from the Munajat asks for the eyes of the heart to pass through even the veils of light. Chapter Eight sets out these veils and the stages in which they are lifted.

The way to God therefore runs through the self. The soul is what we know with, and the one thing we know from within. The Qur'an ties forgetting it to forgetting God, and the saying handed down from the Prophet and Imam ʻAli ties knowing it to knowing Him. Meeting God is the lifting of the veils that cover the soul, before a Lord who is already near.

If the self is the door, how deep does it go?

> **➤ TRY THIS**
>
> After one of the daily prayers each day this week, recite the closing verses of Surah al-Hashr (Q 59:18–24) and reflect on their meaning. This was Shahabadi's practice for his pupils, as Imam Khomeini recalls: "Our Shaykh would ask us to recite these verses after daily prayers and to contemplate over their meaning, especially in the late hours of night when the heart is relaxed"[77]. As you read, notice the warning in verse 19 against forgetting God, and with Him your own soul, and the names of God with which the surah ends.

[77] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 201.

5

The soul and its worlds

إِلٰهِي إِنْ أَنَامَتْنِي ٱلْغَفْلَةُ عَنِ ٱلِاسْتِعْدَادِ لِلِقَائِكَ فَقَدْ نَبَّهَتْنِي ٱلْمَعْرِفَةُ بِكَرَمِ آلَائِكَ

My Lord, if my disregard for preparations to meet You has put me to sleep, my knowledge of Your kind bounties has awakened me.[78]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

These words come from the Munajat Sha'baniyyah, the prayer of the month of Sha'ban. The one who prays admits that neglect has put them to sleep, unprepared to meet God, and that knowing His generosity has woken them. A graveside raises the same thoughts of sleep and of meeting God. There we say that the dead are now in *barzakh*, and many of us picture a waiting room somewhere far away. Sheikh Bahmanpour teaches that at death "we don't go anywhere".

Chapter Four argued that the way to God runs through the self: God is near already, and the journey to Him lifts the veils that cover the heart rather than covering any distance. It ended by asking how deep that self goes. Sleep,

[78]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 166; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §118–119.

which *Lantern of the Path* calls "the brother of death"[79], and death itself both show more of the self than waking life does, and this chapter follows them to an answer. The self lives in more than one world, its deeds give it a form, and what it finally becomes is in our hands.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *ʿalam al-mulk*: the material world · *ʿalam al-mithal*, also called *barzakh*: the middle world of images · *ʿalam al-ʿuqul*: the world of pure intellects · *badan mithali*: the image body · *muraqaba*: watchfulness; keeping the heart's attention on God

Depths, not distances

The mystics hold that the human soul is the whole of creation in small, a compact copy of everything that exists. If that is right, the three powers by which we know things, the senses, the imagination, and the intellect, should each give us a sample of one world, and each world can be approached through something we already know.

The first world is the one our senses meet: *ʿalam al-mulk*, the material world. It is made of matter, things with weight that take up space, such as a table, a hand, or the rain. It is also called the witnessed world, because our senses witness it, and the other two worlds are called unseen. They are unseen not because they are far away but because the ordinary eye does not perceive them without training.

The second world can be approached through the imagination. When we picture a friend's face, the picture has a shape and a colour, yet it weighs nothing and is made of nothing material. A dream does the same thing more vividly. We see people who move and speak, with faces, sizes, and clothes of a certain colour, and none of it is matter.

Our imagination is a sample of a larger world of this kind, *ʿalam al-mithal*, the world of images. That world keeps some features of matter, such as shape, size, and colour, while having no matter at all. The difference is that the picture in our mind belongs to us, whereas the world of images depends on no one's mind. It exists in its own right, and it is the world the dead enter.

The third world can be approached through the intellect. Each person we have met has particular features: a height, a voice, a face. Yet the mind can grasp

[79] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shariʿa), p. 24.

"a human being" with no particular features at all, though no such person exists anywhere outside it. Understanding of this kind deals in meanings, with no image and no matter. Its world is *ʻalam al-ʻuqul*, the world of intellects, and its inhabitants, the angels, are pure intellect, attached to nothing material.

The world of images stands between the other two, and this is why it is also called *barzakh*, a barrier. Pure intellect and matter have nothing in common, so they cannot meet directly, and a middle world is needed to bring them together. Whatever is in the world of intellects is reflected first in the world of images, which has something of matter's shape and colour without its weight, before anything reaches the world of matter.

None of these worlds is a place we travel to. In Sheikh Bahmanpour's words, the world of images "is another dimension of the same world in which we are living", and so is the world of intellects. The unseen worlds surround this one as an envelope surrounds a letter, except that the surrounding is in depth and not in distance: each is a deeper dimension of the world we are in now. The tradition names still greater realms beyond them, the Footstool (*kursi*), the Throne (*ʻarsh*), and *jabarut*, which no one can picture.

This changes the picture at the graveside. The dead have not been taken to a distant room; they have passed into a deeper dimension of the world we are living in. Even the resurrection is not a journey elsewhere but a move deeper still, closer to the majesty and beauty of God.

> **ع WORD STUDY: BARZAKH**
> A *barzakh* is a barrier, something that stands between two things and keeps each in its place. The Qur'an uses the word for the barrier God set between two seas that He merged, one sweet and one briny (Q 25:53). The 'urafa' use it for the world of images, which stands between matter and pure intellect and links them. Mohammad Ali Shomali notes that philosophers compare the body of that world with the bodies we see in dreams, and "call them 'Barzakh' or 'mithali'"[80]. The Qur'an also uses the word of death. When death comes, the verse says, a person asks to be taken back so that he may act righteously in what he left behind, and he is told that a barzakh stands before him until the day he is raised (Q 23:99–100). The barrier stands between this life and the resurrection.

[80] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 76.

A soul that crosses them

The soul has a share in each of the three worlds. Chapter Four said that it carries something of the spirit God breathed into the first human being (Q 15:29). A soul was needed, on this teaching, because pure spirit and a body of clay have nothing in common, so something that reaches both had to stand between them, as the world of images stands between the world of intellects and ours. Each of us has an existence here and a counterpart in the world of images, and the counterpart is far larger than the self that walks about here.

For now the soul's attention is held almost wholly by the body, so it lives in the witnessed world. There are three times when that hold loosens: in sleep, at death, and in contemplation.

The first is sleep. When we sleep, the soul attends less to the body. With the senses no longer crowding out its other perceptions, it can touch the world of images, though it does not leave the body completely; if it did, we would be dead. This explains a dream that is more than memory. A person may see someone in a dream doing something that later happens, and a memory cannot show the future. Time works differently in the middle world, and the soul has seen there the counterpart of an event that has not yet happened here.

The Qur'an sets sleep and death side by side in Surah al-Zumar.

ٱللَّهُ يَتَوَفَّى ٱلْأَنفُسَ حِينَ مَوْتِهَا وَٱلَّتِي لَمْ تَمُتْ فِي مَنَامِهَا ۖ

Allah takes the souls at the time of their death, and those who have not died, in their sleep.

Qur'an 39:42

The verse speaks of the soul being taken in both, and Mohammad Ali Shomali explains the difference of degree. In sleep the spirit is still connected with the body, "but to a lesser degree than waking". At death it is disconnected from the body and "belongs to another body which has the qualities of a material body like shape and size without the mass"[81]. This second body is the *badan mithali*, the image body: it has our shape, but it is not made of any material elements.

[81] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, pp. 75–76.

Death, then, is not the soul slipping out of a body that held it. "The body is not carrying the soul but the soul is carrying the body," Sheikh Bahmanpour says, and when the appointed time comes, the soul sets the body down and goes. It does not go without a body, because a soul cannot be without one. The image body was with us all along, in another dimension and unseen, and the soul goes on in it. The image body is not the soul itself; it is the body the soul has in the middle world.

The third loosening can happen while we are awake. Sleep showed that when the soul's attention leaves the body, it touches the middle world. A person who turns that attention to Allah until they become unaware of the body does the same thing awake, and sees there as one sees in sleep. This is the work of *muraqaba*, watchfulness: keeping the heart's attention on God. Nothing leaves the body in it, the Sheikh makes clear; what is turned is the attention.

ʿAllama Tabataba'i was known for such moments. They come to the mystics, Sheikh Bahmanpour explains, as an opportunity given by Allah and not as a power to be used; only the Imams (as) can pass between the worlds at will. The more Tabataba'i kept up his muraqaba, he said, the more distinctly he saw. None of this is the aim of the path. Chapter One placed that aim in God alone: powers of any kind, sought for themselves, make the goal something other than God.

STORY: QADI MEETS HIMSELF

Kernel of the Kernels, the record of ʿAllama Tabataba'i's lectures on the path, describes what may come to a traveller who keeps up muraqaba. Lights appear, at first like flashes of lightning, and "these lights belong to the class of entities of the realm of Barzakh". In the early stages the traveller may see his own soul in bodily form: "he might see himself standing before himself." The lectures then tell of their teacher, Mirza ʿAli Aqa Qadi, who used to say: "One day emerging from the room into the veranda, I saw myself standing silent by my side. I looked very carefully at my face, and observed a mole on it. On returning to my room when I looked into the mirror, I saw that there was a mole on my face that I had not noticed until then"[82].

[82] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 17.

Sleep, death, and contemplation show a soul that can move between worlds. The angels show what it is to have no such movement, and Surah al-Saffat gives their own words.

وَمَا مِنَّآ إِلَّا لَهُۥ مَقَامٌ مَّعْلُومٌ ﴿١٦٤﴾

There is none among us but has a known place.

Qur'an 37:164

Each angel has a known place, a fixed station that it cannot rise above. An angel does not change or grow, because it is made as it will always be. The human soul is different. It can move and change, and no one knows how far it can go; the mystics say that this capacity is why the angels bowed down to Adam. How far a human soul travels is not settled at its creation, as an angel's station is, and it is left to the life the soul lives.

The form our deeds make

If every soul passes into the middle world in any case, as the dead at the graveside already have, it can seem that what we do here changes little. The answer lies in the image body, and a familiar process shows how. Shomali takes the example of lying. A child telling a first lie feels uneasy and later remorseful; "as one repeats this behaviour though, the soul becomes inured to the effects", until lying costs little effort[83].

Repeated acts shape the self in this way, and some of the shaping shows. A face can show faith or its absence to those with eyes to see it, and a pious person's face can carry light. The change is slow and small, and it never deforms the body. The image body is far more sensitive. Sins deform it and piety makes it shine, so that the image body takes the shape of what the habits have made of the soul.

Imam Khomeini describes this second form in his *Forty Hadith*. Beside the body that everyone can see, each person has "another form and a different face of him, which is heavenly and invisible, which is determined by the qualities of his soul and his inner nature"[84]. The state of the soul when it leaves the

[83] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 20.
[84] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 41.

body fixes that form: “in whichever state one’s soul departs from the body, it assumes a form suited to it in the next world also”[85].

The Qur’an describes people coming forth on the Last Day in Surah al-Naba’.

يَوْمَ يُنفَخُ فِي ٱلصُّورِ فَتَأْتُونَ أَفْوَاجًا ﴿١٨﴾

the day the Trumpet will be blown, and you will come in groups,

Qur’an 78:18

The hadith, as Shomali reports them, say that the groups are formed “according to their true natures”. On that day, “when the veil is finally lifted from before our eyes, we will see ourselves and others as they really are”[86]. Some “could have fallen lower than a bug, while others could have ascended higher than angels”[87]. The last section found that the soul, unlike an angel, has no fixed station. Here is the other side of that freedom: a soul can sink below every animal as well as rise above the angels.

The shining of the pious is described in the Qur’an too, in Surah al-Hadid.

يَوْمَ تَرَى ٱلْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَٱلْمُؤْمِنَٰتِ يَسْعَىٰ نُورُهُم بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَبِأَيْمَٰنِهِم

The day you will see the faithful, men and women, with their light moving swiftly in front of them and on their right

Qur’an 57:12

The light that the faithful carry goes ahead of them and lights their way, and it is their own. Shomali writes of reward and punishment in the same terms. “Sometimes rewards or punishments are nothing other than the actions,” he writes. “They are just the realities of those actions made manifest in another universe”[88].

If a reward can be the deed itself made visible, the form a soul meets after death is in large part the form its own deeds have been giving it. In Shomali’s

[85]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 41.
[86]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 21.
[87]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 21.
[88]Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 77.

words, "our future is now present"[89]. The image body is being shaped today by what we do today.

The self can change its state

If deeds give the soul its form, the self that does the deeds is not fixed either. The Qur'an names the *nafs*, the self, in three states. The first is the self that commands to evil, *al-nafs al-ammara*, named in Surah Yusuf.

إِنَّ ٱلنَّفْسَ لَأَمَّارَةٌۢ بِٱلسُّوٓءِ إِلَّا مَا رَحِمَ رَبِّىٓ ۚ

the [carnal] soul indeed prompts [men] to evil, except inasmuch as my Lord has mercy.

Qur'an 12:53

The verse names the self at its lowest and, in the same breath, the mercy of God that can lift it. The self commands to evil when the bodily side of a person overcomes the spiritual side, and the soul goes after the body's pleasures. The pull is not only towards pleasure. Worrying whether our children will be poor, or whether we will have a good job next year, also binds the soul to the body and keeps it from rising towards God.

The second is the self that blames itself, *al-nafs al-lawwama*, by which Surah al-Qiyama swears.

وَلَآ أُقْسِمُ بِٱلنَّفْسِ ٱللَّوَّامَةِ ﴿٢﴾

And I swear by the self-critical soul!

Qur'an 75:2

After giving in, this self remembers what it has done and asks why it did it. The self-blame is a hopeful sign, because it shows that we hold other values, which matter more to us than the pleasure we gave in to.

The third is the soul at peace, *al-nafs al-mutma'inna*, which Surah al-Fajr calls back to its Lord (Q 89:27), and to which Chapter Seventeen returns. A person who keeps up the self-blame of the second state comes in time to rely

[89] Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 77.

on what belongs to the other world and not on this one. The self then becomes tranquil, free of sin, of greed, and of a mind turned wholly towards the body.

The three are not separate selves. "We don't have different types of nufus," Sheikh Bahmanpour says, using the plural of nafs. The one self takes a different name according to its attitude, and because we can change the attitude, we can change the name.

Sayyid Haydar Amuli, a Shia master of an earlier age, counts four states where the lecture counts three. In his *Inner Secrets of the Path*, the self ascends from "commanding to evil" to the "reproachful", from there to the "inspired", and finally to the station where it is "at rest"[90]. Both counts describe one self climbing. Amuli sets two lines of verse beside the climb: "If the self is neglected, then it keeps company with meanness, / And if it is urged on then, it longs for nobler qualities"[91].

> ع **WORD STUDY: THE LAYERS OF THE SOUL, COUNTED DIFFERENTLY**
> The ʻurafa' give the one soul several names, one for each depth it reaches. Murtada Mutahhari sets out four. When the soul is "dominated and ruled by desires and passions they call it nafs". When it bears divine knowledge it is *qalb*, the heart. When "the light of Divine love dawns within it", it is *ruh*, the spirit, and when it reaches witnessing it is *sirr*, the mystery. Beyond these lie *khafi*, the hidden, and *akhfa*, the most hidden[92]. The lecture's list differs in order and detail: it describes the sirr as known only to God, the khafi as hidden even from the angels, and the qalb as the heart that keeps turning, receiving from God and attending to the body. Imam Khomeini notes that the soul's levels are divided "sometimes into seven sections and sometimes into four", and sometimes into three or two[93]. Chapter Eight takes nafs, qalb, and ruh as stages of the road.

What urges the self on are acts already familiar to us, and the first is the remembrance of God, *dhikr*. Surah al-Raʻd names what it gives.

[90] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 192.
[91] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 192.
[92] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 58.
[93] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 32.

أَلَا بِذِكْرِ ٱللَّهِ تَطْمَئِنُّ ٱلْقُلُوبُ ﴿٢٨﴾

Behold! The hearts find rest in Allah's remembrance!

Qur'an 13:28

The rest the verse promises is the peace of the soul at peace, and only remembrance gives it. On this teaching, meditation that consists of sitting still and thinking of nothing is shallow. Real meditation is reflection inside the soul, and it is carried by dhikr, which refreshes and revives the soul. Chapter Four's verse said that those who forget God are made to forget their own souls (Q 59:19); the reverse holds too, and without remembering God a person cannot come to know their own soul.

Fasting and the night prayer work on the same tie to the body that sleep and muraqaba loosen. The soul manages the body, down to the digestion of a meal, so a body that is not eating asks less of it. In Ramadan Allah pours down His light everywhere, and the soul of the one who fasts, less taken up with the body, takes in that light without knowing it. *Salat al-layl*, the night prayer, likewise helps the soul free itself from the body and see the light.

These acts work because the soul takes on habits quickly. Trained to worry about the body, it worries about the body; trained to care for higher things, it comes to care for them and to see the light. In the lecture's image, the soul is like a fine elastic thing that can be held in the palm of a hand or stretched to the size of the universe, and it has been entrusted to us for a short time. Whatever we do with it, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, "would remain with us forever".

The self is therefore deeper than it appears. It lives in the material world and in the world of images, and it reaches towards the world of intellects; it passes into the middle world a little each night in sleep and fully at death. Its deeds give it a form that it will meet there, and the self that does them can move from commanding, to blaming, to peace. What it finally becomes has been entrusted to us, and it is in our hands.

What keeps so inward a work from going astray?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> *Lantern of the Path* gives an intention for going to sleep. For one week, as you lie down each night, make it your own: "to lighten your burden on the angels

and disengage the self from its appetites, and to examine yourself by your sleep”[94]. With it, the Lantern asks you to “be aware of the fact that you are incapable and weak”[95]. Let sleep be your “last affair in this world”, and remember Allah “with your heart and your tongue” before it comes[96].

[94] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 24.
[95] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 24.
[96] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 25.

6

No path outside the law

وَلاَ يَغْفُلُ عَنْ شُكْرِكَ وَلاَ يَسْتَخِفُّ بِأَمْرِكَ

who do not fail to show You their gratitude and do not take Your orders lightly[97]

Munajat Sha'baniyyah

These words come near the end of the Munajat Sha'baniyyah. They describe the people among whom the one who prays asks to be counted: those who remember God always, never fail to thank Him, and never take His commands lightly. Remembering God and keeping His law are asked for in one line.

Most of us know how easily the two come apart. We stand for salah, raise our hands, and say *Allahu akbar*, and within moments the mind has turned to whether the car was locked. The prayer still counts as valid by the law, which judges its outward form[98], yet the remembering has slipped away.

Chapter Five found the self deeper than it appears, shaped by its own deeds and with its final form in our hands, and asked what keeps so inward a work

[97]Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 166; *Munajat Sha'baniyyah* (duas.org), §126–127.

[98]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 293.

from going astray. This chapter's answer is the law, in which the rules we keep and the remembering we lose are one thing at different depths.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *shari'a*: the sacred law; what the Prophet ﷺ taught us to do · *tariqa*: the path; the inward way of doing what the law asks · *haqiqa*: the truth that the path leads to · *ihsan*: the highest level of faith, worship aware of God's presence · *karamat*: wonders worked by those close to God

Shell, core, and kernel

The 'urafa' use three words for the depths of the religion. The first is *shari'a*, the law: how and when to pray and to fast, and what each act needs before it is valid. This is what most of us mean by practising the religion. Yet the law is not kept for its own sake. We pray and fast to draw near to God, and the way from the law to that nearness is called *tariqa*, a path.

The path is the inward side of the law. Suppose we prayed beside the Prophet ﷺ and copied every movement he made. A jurist watching would rule both prayers valid, because the form of an act is all a jurist can judge. What passed in the Prophet's heart, and in ours, lies beyond any ruling, and that inward way of doing the act is the tariqa. It leads to *haqiqa*, the truth: what the Prophet saw by praying as he prayed.

A saying attributed to the Prophet puts the three in one line. "The shari'ah is my words, tariqah my actions, haqiqah my states"[99]. His words tell us what to do. His actions show how it is done from within, inside the outward frame of the law, and his states are what he saw by doing it.

Because each depth lies inside the one before, none of them can be skipped. Sheikh Bahmanpour gives an image for this that he credits to Najm al-Din Kubra, the master of one of the Sufi orders. The law is a ship, the path is a sea, and the truth is a pearl within it. The pearl "cannot be found except by sailing through the sea, and you cannot sail without a ship". This order is why the prologue counted the shari'a as the beginning of 'irfan, and the boundary of every step after it.

Mulla 'Abd al-Samad Hamadani, a Shia 'arif who had a hadith of the Ahl al-Bayt (as) ready for every point of the path, puts the same order without the

[99] Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 32.

image. The law, the path, and the truth, he taught, are different names for one reality seen from different sides, and they differ only in depth: the shariʿa is the shell, the tariqa the core, and the haqiqa the kernel.[100]

Hamadani found all three depths in a single salah. As service to God, *khidma*, the prayer is at the depth of the law. As a drawing near, *qurb*, it is at the depth of the path, and as an arrival, *wusul*, it is at the depth of the truth.[101] One prayer holds all three, and a prayer like the Prophet's serves God, draws near to Him, and arrives.

The levels of faith, *islam*, *iman*, and *ihsan*, follow the same order. Islam is submission, doing what the law asks. Surah al-Hujurat marks the step from islam to iman, when some Bedouins claim more than they have.

قَالَتِ ٱلۡأَعۡرَابُ ءَامَنَّاۖ قُل لَّمۡ تُؤۡمِنُواْ وَلَٰكِن قُولُوٓاْ أَسۡلَمۡنَا وَلَمَّا يَدۡخُلِ ٱلۡإِيمَٰنُ فِي قُلُوبِكُمۡۖ*

The Bedouins say, 'We have faith.' Say, 'You do not have faith yet; rather, say, "We have embraced Islam," for faith has not yet entered into your hearts.'

Qur'an 49:14

The Bedouins had made the outward submission, whereas faith is the meaning of that submission entering the heart. Ihsan, the highest level, is worship aware of God's presence. Surah al-Dhariyat describes its people, the *muhsinin*, by their nights: they slept little, and at dawn they pleaded for forgiveness (Q 51:16–18). Like the law, the path, and the truth, each of these levels is built on the one below it, and none stands without it.[102]

The inner never cancels the outer

If the truth is reached only through the law, someone who claims the truth while setting the law aside has left the ship. Kubra draws this conclusion from his own image. Suppose a person is seen flying in the air, walking on the sea,

[100]Murtada Mutahhari gives the same order: "One is outward shell, another is inward kernel, and the third is the kernel of the kernel." Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 15.

[101]Sayyid Haydar Amuli records the saying: "Surely prayer is service, a coming closer and an arrival." Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 32.

[102]Sayyid Haydar Amuli puts the order as a rule: "shariʿah is possible without tariqah although tariqah is not possible without shariʿah." Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 48.

or eating fire. Of anyone who does such things and has abandoned "even one injunction of God", Kubra says, "you should know that they are liars".

"Liars" here does not mean that the feats are faked, since such things can be done. The lie is in the claim to know God. The person works these wonders for their own desires, and what they do is not a *karama*, a wonder of the friends of God, but magic. Chapter One met these wonders from the other side. There, training the soul to gain them was named shirk, setting up a partner beside God, because the aim had become something other than God.

> ع **WORD STUDY: KARAMAT, MUʿJIZA, AND SIHR**
> Chapter One set *karamat* and *muʿjizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets, side by side, and this chapter adds a third word. A *muʿjiza*, a miracle, is worked only by a prophet, by God's permission. A *karama* (plural *karamat*) is a wonder that appears at the hands of someone close to God, worked, in Sheikh Bahmanpour's description, through the strength of the human soul. *Sihr*, magic, produces effects that can look the same by other means, usually the help of the jinn. To an onlooker a flight through the air looks alike whoever performs it, so Kubra's test looks past the feat to the person's keeping of the law, and one abandoned command of God is enough to mark the feat as magic.

The law cannot be skipped because of what it does to the one who keeps it. Ayatullah Muhammad Bahari, an Iranian ʿarif, set out the order. Jurisprudence, he taught, is "an introductory means" to purifying one's character, and good character is the way into knowledge of God's oneness, *tawhid*.

The chain runs in one direction only. Without the law lived in oneself there is no good character, and without good character there is no knowledge of God, since that knowledge comes through purifying the self and not through study. A traveller who claims to have become an ʿarif and to need the law no longer, as if it were meant for ordinary people, has broken the first link.

Chapter Two reached the same point from the side of knowledge: purification begins with practising the shariʿa, and the purified heart receives the knowledge of God as a light. Imam Khomeini states it from the side of the law. In his words, "Without adhering to the apparent teachings of Islam it is not possible that the light of the Divine Knowledge could descend upon

his heart"[103].

Nor does the light, once it has come, loosen the law. A person to whom the truth has been unveiled, Imam Khomeini continues, acts "with greater observance of the manifest forms of religion". This, he writes, "falsifies the claims of pseudo spiritualists, who say that the inner perfection can only be acquired by relinquishing outer accomplishments"[104].

Experiences that bypass the law are also far easier to come by than the law itself. Sheikh Bahmanpour warns that anyone, of any belief, who goes forty days on less and less food will find something, and because the knowledge of God is so unfamiliar to us, whatever is found is taken for God.

Keeping the law is the harder discipline. It asks for worship every day and night and at every dawn, and for watchfulness at every moment over a tongue that might backbite and ears that might listen to what is vile. A forty-day exercise ends, whereas the law has to be kept for a whole life, and the true ʿarif is the one who keeps it without a break.

That lifelong keeping of the law is also where the first inner work is done, inside the prayers we already pray. The tariqa is the purifying of how we practise the shariʿa, giving it more depth each time, and it begins at *Allahu akbar*, where we have to know what we are saying. What makes this hard is that attention cannot be held. The eyes can be closed and the tongue kept still, yet attention moves elsewhere the moment it is turned towards God.

The thought about the car arrives at exactly this point. Someone standing at the edge of a cliff would not wonder about the car, because the danger is in front of them, and the same ought to be true of standing before God. The logic is sound, but no one can bring that sense of presence to prayer simply by deciding to. Saying the words from the heart needs a knowledge that comes only after the words have been practised and taken in, while that practice needs the same attention that keeps slipping. This is a vicious circle, and it is the whole difficulty of the tariqa.

Imam Khomeini puts the difficulty as a question: "How is it that the study of a book often absorbs man's entire attention, but prayer does not?"[105]. A

[103] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 35.
[104] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 35.
[105] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 135.

book can hold the mind entirely, so the faculty of attention is not missing. In *Forty Hadith* he names the two things that bring it to worship: "possessing unoccupied time and an unoccupied heart", and "making one's heart understand the importance of worship"[106].

The circle is broken by degrees. The tariqa gives the practice more depth each time it is done, and besides the obligatory and recommended prayers the shari'a gives many remembrances whose purpose is to turn more of our thought and time towards God. Chapter Ten returns to these disciplines.

To the last breath

The inner never cancels the outer at the start of the road, and the same holds at its end. Some have claimed that a traveller who reaches the higher stations is spared the obligations of the law. 'Allama Tabataba'i, in the lectures recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, rejects the claim, writing that "from the beginning of wayfaring to its final stage the wayfarer must abide by all the precepts of the luminous Shari'ah"[107]. The claim of release he calls "a big lie and slander"[108].

His reason is the Prophet ﷺ himself, who kept every precept of the law until the last moments of his life though he was the noblest of all creation[109], so no traveller reaches a station where the law no longer applies. Tabataba'i's test matches Kubra's. Anyone who claims to be a wayfarer while departing from the law even slightly is to be considered a hypocrite, unless the lapse comes from error, an excuse, or forgetfulness[110].

Worship does take on another meaning at the end of the road, and Tabataba'i explains how. For a soul still growing towards its perfection, the acts of worship are the means of that growth, whereas for one that has reached it they are no longer for growth[111]. The Prophet was once asked why he took such pains in worship when God had promised him forgiveness (Q 48:2), and he replied with a question.

[106] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 375.
[107] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[108] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[109] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[110] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[111] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.

Don't you want me to be God's grateful servant?[112]

Hadith

For such a soul, Tabataba'i concludes, worship is "purely for the sake of expression of thankfulness and gratitude to God Almighty"[113]. The Munajat line at the head of this chapter asks to be among those who do not fail to show God their gratitude and do not take His orders lightly. In the Prophet's worship the two are one act, since keeping God's commands is itself the thanks.

The road's last stage is also lived among people, not above them. The ʿurafa' describe the completed journey as four journeys: from creation to God; in God, by God; from God back to creation, by God; and in creation, by God. The traveller who has reached God returns to creation in the third journey and travels the fourth in its midst, and Chapter Sixteen walks all four.

There is therefore no inner path outside the shariʿa. The law, the path, and the truth are one religion at three depths, and each depth is reached only through the one before it. Nothing inward stands in for the law: wonders worked without it are magic, and the light of knowing God does not descend on a heart that has set it aside. The law holds to the end of the road, where the Prophet kept it to the last moments of his life as an act of gratitude.

The law is the boundary. Who walks beside the traveller?

> **TRY THIS**
>
> For one prayer each day this week, pray at the start of its time, with nothing planned straight after it. Imam Khomeini advises that one "should set aside a certain time out of his day and night hours exclusively for the sake of worship", and that salat be carried out "in the most meritorious part of its time"[114]. At *Allahu akbar*, follow Sheikh Bahmanpour's advice and "know what you are saying". When the mind turns to something else, bring it back to the words of the prayer.

[112] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[113] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 30.
[114] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 375.

7

Finding a guide

On Fridays many of us read Surah al-Kahf[115]. Halfway through it, the Prophet Musa (as) sets out on a journey, telling the young man with him that he will keep going until he reaches the meeting place of the two seas, however long it takes (Q 18:60). There he finds a servant of God who has been taught knowledge from God's own presence (Q 18:65), the servant known as Khidr[116]. Musa makes him one request.

قَالَ لَهُۥ مُوسَىٰ هَلْ أَتَّبِعُكَ عَلَىٰٓ أَن تُعَلِّمَنِ مِمَّا عُلِّمْتَ رُشْدًا ﴿٦٦﴾

Moses said to him, 'May I follow you for the purpose that you teach me some of the probity you have been taught?'

Qur'an 18:66

A prophet to whom God spoke asked to follow a teacher, and had been ready to travel for a long time to find him. Chapter Six argued that the shari'a marks the boundary of the road from the first step to the last, and it ended by asking

[115] Shaykh 'Abbas Qummi, *Mafatih al-Jinan*, p. 85.
[116] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 508.

who walks beside the traveller. This chapter's answer is a guide: one who helps, and who must be tested.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET *shaykh*: a spiritual instructor · *murid*: a disciple · *silsila*: a chain of masters traced back to the Prophet ﷺ · *wali* (plural *awliya'*): a friend of God · *wusul*: arrival at the goal of the road

Why a companion

Chapter Two described the knowledge of God as a light that God places in a purified heart, and noted that this light can pass from one heart to another. Receiving it straight from God is possible but difficult, so most travellers receive it through someone who has received it already. The reason is that the road has turns a traveller cannot read alone, and the turns are in the soul itself.

On the journey the soul can pass into states that the traveller does not understand. There may come a time when a traveller hates worship, or cannot bear to live among people. Such states arrive without explanation, and a traveller who does not know what they mean, or what to do next, can lose the way. Someone who has already passed through them can explain them. The traveller describes what they feel and is told what it means and what to do next, down to which words of remembrance suit that stage, *Allahu akbar* or *la ilaha illa Allah*.

How early in the journey that need begins is where the scholars differ. Sheikh Bahmanpour does not make a beginner wait for a guide. Many who want to set out look first for a teacher, and when they cannot find one they conclude that they cannot begin. In his account the guide who can read the soul's states is found only once a traveller has moved past the first steps towards the deeper side of 'irfan, and the first steps are the law: "First you have to comply completely with whatever Sharia tells."

At the start a teacher is needed in a narrower sense, to say which of the practices handed down in the hadith matter most at the beginning. Mirza 'Ali Aqa Qadi had beginners recite the Musabbihat, the five surahs that open with God's glorification and that the Prophet ﷺ recited every night before sleeping, for a whole year before he gave them a second instruction.

The Sufi orders, by contrast, tell the beginner to come to them and to act on nothing without their instruction, or be lost on the path, a claim he calls "something of an exaggeration".

Murtada Mutahhari weighs the need for a guide more heavily, and places it at every stage. Each stage of the path, in his account, must be passed under the guidance of "a mature and perfect example of humanity who, having traveled this path, is aware of the manners and ways of each station". Without such a guide, the traveller "is in danger of going astray"[117].

The 'urafa', Mutahhari adds, call this master Khidr, the name of the servant Musa followed in Surah al-Kahf. He quotes a verse of their poetry that asks for that company: "Leave not this stage without the company of Khidr, / There is darkness ahead; be afraid of losing the way"[118].

A guide beside the Imam, not in his place

If a guide is needed, the next question is what authority he holds. The Sufi orders give one answer. Each order calls itself a *tariqa*, the word Chapter Six used for the inward path, and is built round an elder with his own method of instruction. Each has a *silsila*, a chain of masters that it traces back to the Prophet ﷺ. Through that chain, the orders hold, the Prophet's inner knowledge passed from heart to heart, from each master to the next.

Shia hold that the Prophet's inner knowledge did pass on, and that belief leaves no room for the chain. It passed by inheritance to the Imams (as), which is why Imam ʿAli (as) is not counted as one companion among others, however learned the others were. The orders, Sheikh Bahmanpour observes, keep the idea of an authority who receives the Prophet's inner knowledge, without believing in the Imam. For Shia that authority is the Imam, and so "We don't have such a thing as tariqa in Shia."

The orders also ask for a particular kind of obedience: a *murid*, a disciple, submits to the *shaykh* completely, whatever he says and whatever he does. Shia travellers do not join an order. They find an instructor for themselves, one who comes from no order and holds no special licence to instruct, and what

[117] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 10.
[118] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 10.

they look for is a person they can trust, someone to whom "you could entrust your soul".

ʿAllama Tabataba'i sets out where such a teacher stands, and he distinguishes two teachers. The first, the general teacher, has not been specially appointed to guide anyone. Consulting him is like consulting any knowledgeable person, as a verse of Surah al-Nahl tells believers to do[119].

فَسْـَٔلُوٓاْ أَهْلَ ٱلذِّكْرِ إِن كُنتُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ ﴿٤٣﴾

Ask the People of the Reminder if you do not know.

Qur'an 16:43

Asking those who know is the traveller's relation to a general teacher, and it lasts for a stretch of the road: once the traveller is honoured with visions of God's Attributes and Essence, Tabataba'i writes, "his company is not necessary". The special teacher is different. He is the one "specially designated to guide, and they are the Apostle of Allah and his true successors"[120].

Of the special teacher Tabataba'i is categorical: "The wayfarer cannot dispense with the company of the special teacher in any circumstance whatsoever, even if he has reached his sought homeland." The company he means is not physical. It is "the inner company of the Imam with the wayfarer"[121], present at every stage of the road and after its end[122]. A guide is consulted and trusted for a stretch of the road, whereas the company that never ends belongs to the Imam. Chapter Fifteen returns to how this position differs from the Sufi orders, with their chains and their pledges.

Teachers within living memory

If Shia travellers find an instructor for themselves, there must be instructors to find, and the tradition can name teachers who walked this road within living memory. ʿAllama Tabataba'i, lecturing on the path in Qum in 1949–50[123], named his own: "My preceptor was the late Haji Mirza Ali Agha Qazi who

[119] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80.
[120] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80.
[121] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 80.
[122] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.
[123] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 9.

was a pupil of Agha Sayyid Ahmad Karbalai”[124]. Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi is the teacher under whom, as Chapter One noted, Tabataba’i travelled the path[125], and his instruction was practical: set a time each day or night to attend to the self, “for half an hour or a little more”[126].

The line goes back further. Karbala’i was one of the pupils of Akhund Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani, a different scholar from the Hamadani of Chapter Six, who found the law, the path, and the truth in a single prayer. Akhund Hamadani had been a distinguished student of jurisprudence before he was a guide[127], and he had been trained by a judge whose own guide was a weaver no one could identify, as the box below tells.

Akhund Hamadani’s other pupils included Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi[128], who taught Imam Khomeini’s first formal classes in gnosis and ethics, in Qum[129].

They were scholars, several of them jurists, and Tabataba’i is plain that the line he follows stands outside the Sufi orders: “we belong to none of these orders and follow the directions of the late Akhund, who had nothing to do with these orders”[130]. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls Tabataba’i a symbol of Shia mysticism in our time, the mysticism practised by scholars and not by the orders.

Their method was the one Chapter Four described, in which the way to God runs through the self, because the soul is the one thing we know from within and whoever knows his own self knows his Lord. Akhund Hamadani taught concentration on the self, and all his disciples followed “the method of gnosis (ma’rifah) of the soul, which is essential to the gnosis of the Lord”[131].

STORY: THE WEAVER AT THE JUDGE'S DOOR

[124]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.
[125]‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 8.
[126]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 107.
[127]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.
[128]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.
[129]Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.
[130]Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 105.
[131]‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 87.

More than a hundred years before ʿAllama Tabataba'i wrote, Sayyid ʿAli Shushtari was a leading scholar and judge in the city of Shushtar. One day a weaver knocked at his door and told him that a ruling he had given on a property was wrong. The property belonged to an orphan, the weaver said, and its deed was buried in a certain place. Shushtari found the deed where the weaver had said, and found that the witnesses had lied. The weaver returned on the next two nights with the same warning, and on the third told him to sell his belongings, go to Najaf, and wait for him there. Shushtari went, followed the weaver's instructions, and "reached a position too high to be described". In Najaf he attended Shaykh Murtada Ansari's lectures on jurisprudence and took over Ansari's teaching after his death. In the six months he had left to live, he trained Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani[132]. Tabataba'i traces his own line of teachers back to the weaver through Shushtari, and adds that "it is not known who that weaver was"[133].

How to test a guide

A line of true teachers does not make every teacher who claims a place in it true, so a guide must be tested. The question is whether he has walked the road himself, and his learning does not answer it. Knowledge of the road is not the kind that study yields, as Chapter Two argued, so it cannot be read from what a teacher has written or studied.

Wonders do not answer it either. Chapter Six gave Najm al-Din Kubra's rule: someone seen flying through the air or walking on the sea, who has abandoned a single command of God, is lying in his claim to know God.

Tabataba'i goes further. No one can tell that a person has reached *wusul*, the goal of the road, from "extraordinary feats, knowledge of hidden things, of private thoughts of persons, passing over fire and water", or from knowledge of the past and the future[134]. Such powers become possible early on the road, when the soul first begins to see what is hidden[135], and "there is a very great distance between this point and the frontiers of wusul and perfection"[136]. A wonder shows that a person sees what others do not. It does not show that he

[132] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 105–106.
[133] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 106.
[134] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.
[135] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.
[136] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.

is a *wali*, a friend of God[137].

What Tabataba'i asks of a teacher is far beyond any wonder. A general teacher, he writes, must have reached a rank of perfection at which "Satan despairs of misleading him", "for otherwise one may not surrender oneself to everyone and anyone and submit and obey him"[138].

What shows a guide is time. The general teacher, Tabataba'i writes, "is not recognized except through company and being with him in public and private", until the traveller knows his reality and his certainty for sure[139]. A traveller comes to know a guide as anyone comes to know a person, by living alongside him, as Maliki Tabrizi lived for fourteen years alongside his.

> ◈ **WHO'S WHO: MIRZA JAWAD MALIKI TABRIZI**
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> Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, "The most distinguished jurisprudent and perfect mystic" in his biographer's words, studied jurisprudence in Najaf under the great jurists of his day. There he came to know Akhund Mulla Husayn-Quli Hamadani, and he spent fourteen years with him, learning ethics and mysticism. He became a guide in his turn: the jurist Shaykh Muhammad Husayn Isfahani, himself an authority in learning and deeds, wrote asking for his instructions in ethics and mysticism. Maliki Tabrizi later settled in Qum, where he taught jurisprudence and ethics and wrote[140]. He died in 1925, and three years later his ethics class was resumed by Mirza Muhammad ʿAli Shahabadi, the teacher of Imam Khomeini whom Chapter Four introduced. When Shahabadi left for Tehran in 1936, he gave the class to Imam Khomeini[141].

Long company matters because the road has many pretenders. Tabataba'i quotes a Persian couplet: "A thousand trap lies concealed in this wilderness, / Not one out of a million finds deliverance there from"[142]. A traveller, he warns, must not surrender himself to everyone who "exhibits his merchandise and puts out his wares on display", with claims to unveiling and inner sight[143].

[137] Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.

[138] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 82–83.

[139] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 81.

[140] Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, *The Spiritual Journey of the Mystics*, p. 8.

[141] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 8.

[142] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83.

[143] ʿAllama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83.

Imam Khomeini describes such pretenders sharply. Those who style themselves guides of God's creatures and leaders of mystic orders, he writes, "have distracted the attention of the creatures of God from Him, attracting them towards themselves"[144]. Chapter One argued that 'irfan is sought for God alone and never for powers, and the same aim tests the guide: a false guide leaves people looking at him, whereas a true guide turns them towards God.

Not every traveller can keep long company with a teacher before trusting him, and Tabataba'i gives a test for that case too. Where it is hard to inquire into a teacher's state, the traveller should trust in God and weigh whatever the teacher says or prescribes "in the light of the Book of God and the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allah and the practice of the Immaculate Imams"[145]. Only what agrees is put into practice, so a guide who cannot be known in person is measured by the Book, the Sunna, and the practice of the Imams (as).

The simplest form of the test comes in a saying of the Prophet 'Isa (as), recorded in *Lantern of the Path*, the book attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (as). His companions asked him with whom they should sit.

> *With one the sight of whom reminds you of Allah, ... and whose speech increases you in knowledge, and whose actions make you desire the next world.*[146]
>
> Lantern of the Path

Checking these three marks needs no inner sight. Any believer can ask what a person's presence turns them towards, what his speech adds to what they know, and what his conduct makes them want.

A guide therefore helps, and must be tested. Part Two has described what a traveller needs before setting out: the self, through which the road runs and which is deeper than it looks; the shari'a, which bounds the road; and a guide who has walked it, trusted beside the Imam, and tested by the law, by long company, and by where he turns people's attention.

Once a guide is found, what does the road itself look like?

[144] Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 102.
[145] 'Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), p. 83.
[146] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 13.

➤ TRY THIS

This week, notice the people whose company you keep: at the mosque, at a majlis, at work, and at home. Of each, ask the three questions in ‘Isa’s answer. Does the sight of them remind you of Allah? Does their speech increase you in knowledge? Do their actions make you desire the next world[147]? Where you find someone of whom all three are true, seek out their company.

[147] *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 13.